

Daily Content Intel

May 27, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, here's something I keep seeing in my athletes and honestly in myself. You have a rough day, you sleep on it, and the next morning it feels smaller. That's not a metaphor. There's a stage of sleep doing that work for you.

It's REM sleep, the dreaming stage. Researchers think one of its jobs is to take the emotional charge off yesterday's experiences, so the memory stays and the sting fades. Your brain replays the day in a calmer chemical state and turns the volume down on it.

In one study they selectively cut people's REM sleep, kept the rest of

their sleep mostly intact, and the next day those people reported more negative mood and their threat centers, the amygdala, fired harder during a social-stress task. Same stress, bigger reaction, because the overnight reset didn't happen.

Here's why I care as a PT. If you're rehabbing an injury or pushing hard in training, you're carrying physical stress and emotional stress at the same time. Short sleep doesn't just slow tissue healing, it leaves you more reactive, more anxious, kind of raw. And then we wonder why the rehab feels harder than it should.

So before you add another supplement or another recovery gadget, protect the back half of your night. That's where most of your REM lives. Late alcohol and a 5am alarm both steal it first.

Sleep is a recovery tool. Probably the best one I've got, and it's free.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Your worst mood tomorrow might be a sleep problem, not a life problem.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, here's something I keep seeing in my athletes and honestly in myself. You have a rough day, you sleep on it, and the next morning it feels smaller. That's not a metaphor. There's a stage of sleep doing that work for you.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 "Bad mood tomorrow = sleep problem?"

- 0:08 REM sleep = emotional reset
- 0:20 Cut REM > worse next-day mood + amygdala fires harder
- 0:38 Physical stress + emotional stress stack
- 0:52 Protect the back half of your night
- 1:05 Sleep is a recovery tool

Caption (copy-paste ready):

You slept on it and it felt smaller the next day. That's REM sleep doing its job.

Researchers think one role of the dreaming stage is to pull the emotional charge off yesterday while keeping the memory. Cut REM in a lab and people wake up in a worse mood with a more reactive threat response to the same stress.

For anyone rehabbing or training hard: you're carrying physical and emotional load at once. Short sleep leaves you raw and makes the work feel harder than it is. Protect the back half of your night before you buy another recovery gadget.

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#sleep #recovery #physicaltherapy
#athletedevelopment #REMsleep
#stressmanagement #rehab #threshold

Personalize this

- Which post-op patient story shows this best, someone whose rehab stalled and it traced back to terrible sleep more than the tissue itself?
- How does sleep fit inside your CROSS framework, is it living under Recovery or Stress, and how do you actually coach it without sounding like every other "sleep more" influencer?
- What's your own honest sleep pattern right now, and are you willing to film the part where you admit you're guilty of the 5am-alarm-after-late-night thing?

Key passage:

"Healthy sleep, positive general affect, and the ability to regulate emotional experiences are fundamental for well-being."

Sources:

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7557922/>

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Let's talk about the ice bath, because it's everywhere right now and I think the timing is wrong for most people.

Here's the deal. When you lift, you create a signal. The muscle basically asks the body to build, and that signal runs for hours after you train. A cold plunge right after a hard lifting session blunts that signal. You're telling your body to calm down at the exact moment you wanted it to build up.

A meta-analysis pooled the studies on this, cold water immersion right after resistance training, and the muscle-growth response came out smaller compared to just training and recovering normally. Interesting part, strength held up better than size in some of that data, so it hits the building of new muscle harder than the strength

itself.

I'm not anti cold. Cold plunges feel great, they can help you feel recovered, and if your only goal that day is to bounce back for tomorrow's game, fine. The problem is stacking it right on top of a session where the whole point was to get bigger and stronger.

So here's my call. If you're chasing muscle, put space between the lift and the cold, a few hours at least, or save the plunge for rest days. Don't pay for a hard session and then refund it 10 minutes later.

Train hard. Let the signal run. Then chill.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: If you ice bath right after lifting, you might be deleting your own gains.

Spoken script (word for word):

Let's talk about the ice bath, because it's everywhere right now and I think the timing is wrong for most people.

Here's the deal. When you lift, you create a signal. The muscle basically asks the body to build, and that signal runs for hours after you train. A cold plunge right after a hard lifting session blunts that signal. You're telling your body to calm down at the exact moment you wanted it to build up.

A meta-analysis pooled the studies on this, cold water immersion right after resistance training, and the muscle-growth response came out smaller compared to just training and recovering normally. Interesting part, strength held up better than size in some of that data, so it hits the building of new muscle harder than the strength itself.

I'm not anti cold. Cold plunges feel great, they can help you feel recovered, and if your only goal that day is to bounce back for tomorrow's game, fine. The problem is stacking it right on top of a session where the whole point was to get bigger and stronger.

So here's my call. If you're chasing muscle, put space between the lift and the cold, a few hours at least, or save the plunge for rest days. Don't pay for a hard session and then refund it 10 minutes later.

Train hard. Let the signal run. Then chill.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 "Ice bath after lifting = deleting gains?"
- 0:10 Lifting sends a "build" signal for hours
- 0:22 Cold plunge right after blunts it
- 0:34 Meta-analysis: smaller muscle growth vs normal recovery
- 0:46 Strength held up better than size
- 0:58 Put hours between the lift and the cold

Caption (copy-paste ready):

The cold plunge is everywhere and the timing is wrong for most people. Lifting sends a "build this muscle" signal that runs for hours. Jumping in cold right after blunts it. A

meta-analysis on cold water immersion after resistance training found a smaller muscle-growth response compared to training and recovering normally, and size took a bigger hit than strength.

I'm not anti cold. If your goal is bouncing back for tomorrow's game, plunge away. If your goal is getting bigger and stronger, put a few hours between the lift and the cold, or save it for rest days. Don't pay for a hard session and refund it 10 minutes later.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT
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#coldplunge #icebath #strengthtraining
#hypertrophy #recovery #physicaltherapy
#athletedevelopment #threshold

Personalize this

- Which of your athletes is religious about the ice bath, and would you actually pull it from their post-lift routine or just move the timing, what's the real coaching call?
- Where does this land in CROSS for you, is cold a Recovery tool you'd green-light on conditioning days but red-light right

after a hypertrophy block?

- Do you have a personal take from your own training, a phase where you iced everything and wondered why size stalled, that you'd be willing to put on camera?

Key passage:

"Application of CWI immediately following bouts of RT may attenuate muscle hypertrophy in both trained and untrained individuals."

Sources:

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11235606/>

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Post-training down-regulation drills (orienting, breath pacing) from the Mike T. Nelson / Tracy Holemeyer Flex Diet Podcast, framed as a 2-minute reset athletes can run after a hard session.
- Laborde 2024 HRV recovery-techniques meta-analysis (which recovery methods actually move parasympathetic recovery) once an open-access full text is reachable.
- Fisetin and vascular calcification (Mercola), only if a primary source holds up to scrutiny.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest (newsletter_digest_2026-05-27.pdf): 3 sources processed. Dr. Mercola top story framed one sleep stage as an "emotional recovery system," which lines up with the REM research below. Mike T. Nelson's Flex Diet Podcast with Tracy Holemeyer covered post-training down-regulation,

orienting, and nervous-system recovery, which seeded the recovery angle.

- PubMed / Nature Scientific Reports: REM-sleep suppression study (next-day negative affect + amygdala reactivity). Used the open-access PMC mirror for verbatim quotes.
- European Journal of Sport Science / PMC: cold water immersion vs resistance-training hypertrophy meta-analysis. Strong counter-consensus item, fresh source.
- Laborde 2024 recovery-techniques HRV meta-analysis: relevant but Wiley returned HTTP 402 (paywalled), skipped for verbatim use.
- MDPI 2026 HRV monitoring review: HTTP 403, unreachable, skipped.
- NSCA / APTA / Reddit / Examine / Attia / Huberman: not pulled this run, the digest plus two open-access primaries gave two clean, deduped angles with verbatim gems.